12.9.1 Waste management practices

a) Source segregation

b) Composting

1. Aerobic 2. Anaerobic

c) Vermicomposting

d) Biogas generation

e) Incineration

12.9.2 Radioactive waste

Radioactive wastes are generated during various operations of the nuclear power plant. Radioactive waste can be in gas, liquid or solid form, and its level of radioactivity can vary. The waste can remain radioactive for a few hours or several months or even hundreds of thousands of years. Depending on the level and nature of radioactivity, radioactive wastes can be classified as exempt waste, Low and Intermediate level waste and High Level Waste.

Radioactive waste management

Radioactive waste management involves the treatment, storage, and disposal of liquid, airborne, and solid effluents from the nuclear industry.



The Three Mile Island (Pennsylvania, United States), Chernobyl (Pripyat, Ukraine) and Fukushima Daiichi (Ōkuma, Japan) are nuclear disasters the world has seen in the recent period.

Methods of disposal of radioactive wastes are

1. **Limit generation** - Limiting the generation of waste is the first and most important consideration in managing radioactive wastes.
2. **Dilute and disperse** - For wastes having low radioactivity, dilution and dispersion are adopted.
3. **Delay and decay** - Delay and decay is frequently an important strategy because much of the radioactivity in nuclear reactors and accelerators is very short lived.
4. **Concentrate and confine process** - Concentrating and containing is the objective of treatment activities for longer-lived radioactivity. The waste is contained in corrosion resistant containers and transported to disposal sites. Leaching of heavy metals and radionuclides from these sites is a problem of growing concern.

Control and Management

Three ways are employed to manage nuclear wastes

- **Spent Fuel Pools** - The spent fuel discharged from the reactors is temporarily stored in the reactor pool. The Spent fuel rods are used in stored cooling ponds. They protect the surroundings from radiation and absorb the heat generated during radioactive decay.
- **Vitrification method** – This prevents reaction or degradation of nuclear waste for extended periods of time and encased in dry cement caskets.
- **Geological Repositories** - A deep geological repository is a nuclear waste repository excavated deep within a stable geologic environment. It is suited to provide a high level of long-term isolation and containment without future maintenance. In India at Tarapur and Kalpakkam, a wet storage facility of Spent Fuel is the main mode of storage.

12.9.3 Medical waste

Any kind of waste that contains infectious material generated by hospitals, laboratories, medical research centers, Pharmaceutical companies and Veterinary clinics are called medical wastes.

Medical wastes contain body fluids like blood, urine, body parts and other contaminants, culture dishes, glasswares, bandages, gloves, discarded needles, scalpels, swabs and tissues.

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